

Introduction to lattice based cryptography

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Motivation

- till now most cryptography relied on hardness of finding prime factors or finding the discrete logarithm, ie. RSA, Elliptic Curves, etc
- Shor's algorithm suggests that factorization can be done in polynomial time (on quantum computers).
 - given an odd composite $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, find $d \in \mathbb{Z}$, such that $1 < d < n$ and $d|n$.
- even if quantum computers never reach, the fact that there is a threat, forces us to prepare for it
- real-world example: since 2023/2024 Chrome and Firefox have lattice-based cryptography to the browser for TLS
 - hybrid: X25519 + ML-KEM to establish a symmetric encryption key
 - protect against *harvest now, decrypt later* attacks

Post Quantum Cryptography - Status of the ecosystem

- isogenesis based
- hash based
- codes based
- lattice based
- multivariate based

Motivation (in Ethereum's ecosystem)

- Ethereum, is going with hash-based signatures for the validators.
 - aggregation through SNARK proofs (eg. binus, flock, etc)
 - each slot a different XMSS leaf
 - the most conservative choice in terms of security
- hash-based simpler to implement, less potential errors.
Whereas lattice-based have more subtelties

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 - good for less attacks, not so fun to build stuff with
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 - eg. elliptic curves have algebraic structure, allows for signature aggregation, thresholds, etc
- lattice-based schemes have smaller proofs, signatures and public keys
 - better suited for end-user wallets

First, some tools



Rings, Ideals, Modules, Kernels, ...

Recap of concepts

- **Ring:** a set with addition and multiplication, where addition forms an abelian group and multiplication is associative and distributive over addition.
 - **Ideal:** a subset $I \subseteq R$ closed under addition and under multiplication by arbitrary elements of R .
Intuition: I absorbs products in R .
- **Vector space:** an abelian group of vectors equipped with scalar multiplication by elements of a field.
 - **basis:** linearly independent vectors that span the vector space
ie. for $b_1, \dots, b_n$ a basis of V , then $\forall v \in V$,

$$v = v_1 b_1 + \dots + v_n b_n \in V$$

- **Module:** a generalization of a vector space where the scalars come from a ring instead of necessarily a field.
- **Kernel:** for a homomorphism $f : A \rightarrow B$, the subset $\ker(f) = \{x \in A : f(x) = 0\}$ of elements mapped to zero.

Intuition: inputs that a function completely "erases", ie. turns into zero.

Lattices

Definition (Lattice)

A lattice $\mathcal{L}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$ is the set of all integer linear combinations of m linearly independent vectors $b_1, \dots, b_m \in \mathbb{R}^n$, with $m \leq n$.

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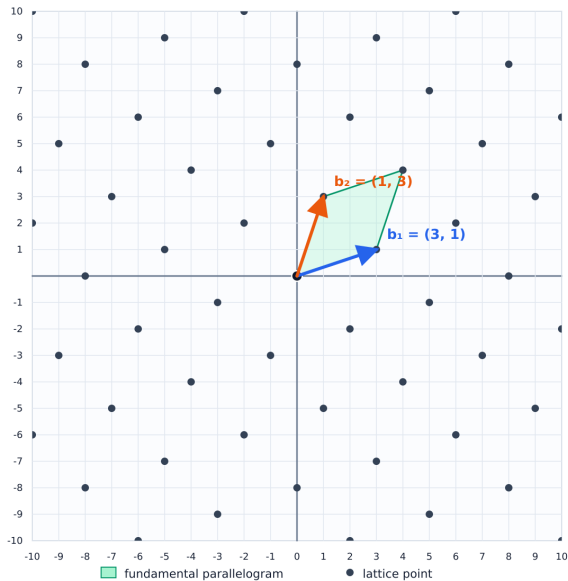
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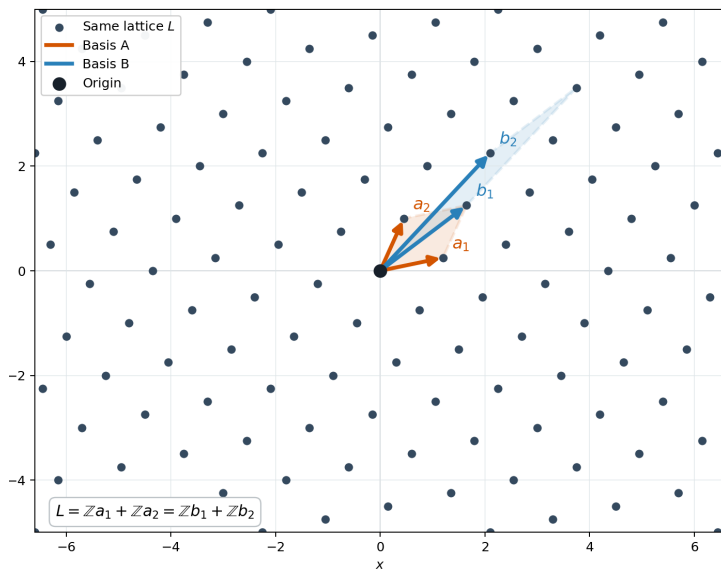
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In most cryptographic applications, $b_1, \dots, b_n \in \mathbb{Z}^n$, ie. $\mathcal{L}$ is an integer lattice.

2-dimensional lattice

$$\Lambda = \{n b_1 + m b_2 : n, m \in \mathbb{Z}\}, b_1 = (3, 1), b_2 = (1, 3)$$





Lattice properties

a n -dimensional lattice $\mathcal{L}$ is

- i. *additive subgroup* of $\mathbb{R}^n$: $\mathcal{L}$ is the nonempty subset of $\mathbb{R}^n$ closed under vector addition (and subtraction),

$$\text{ie. } \forall x, y \in \mathcal{L}, -x, x + y \in \mathcal{L}$$

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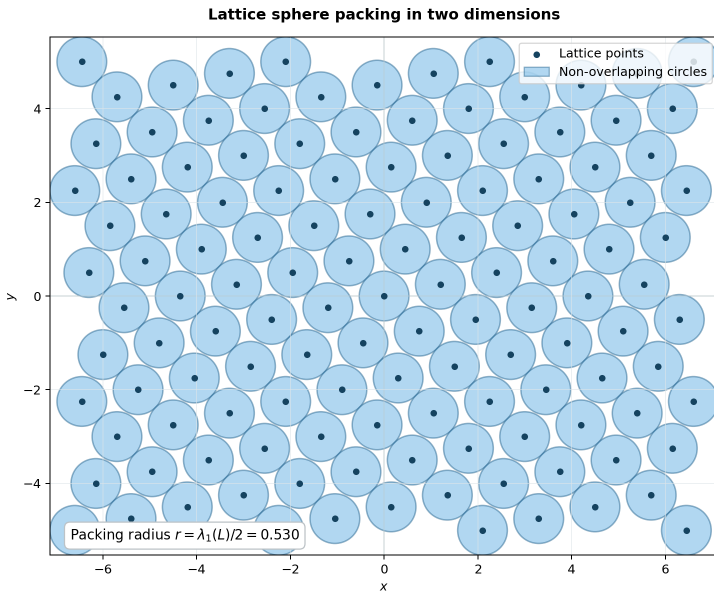
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Successive minima $\lambda_i(\mathcal{L})$: smallest radius r s. th. $\mathcal{L}$ the n -dimensional ball of radius r contains i linearly independent lattice points.

$$\lambda_1(\mathcal{L}) \leq \lambda_2(\mathcal{L}) \leq \dots \leq \lambda_n(\mathcal{L})$$



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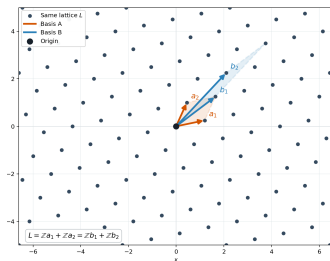
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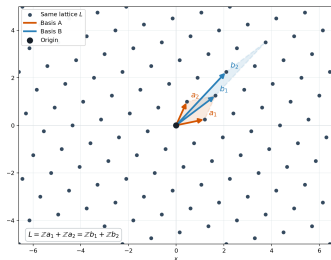
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 - the lattice $\mathcal{L}(B)$ is the invariant set of points
 - the basis B is not unique
- $B \in \mathbb{Z}^{n \times n}$, n vectors, each with n coordinates $\implies$ requires $\mathcal{O}(n^2)$ integers.
 - only if we could have some better lattice structure to represent the lattice with fewer entries...



q-ary lattice

a full-rank lattice is q-ary if $q\mathbb{Z}^d \subseteq \mathcal{L} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^d$

$\implies$ q-ary lattice is an infinite set of integer points, but membership depends only on the residue class modulo q

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$$\mathcal{L}_q^\perp(A) = \ker(\psi_A) = \{z \in \mathbb{Z}^m \mid Az = 0 \pmod{q}\}$$

contains all vectors that are orthogonal modulo q to the rows of A .

Intuition: keep only the points that satisfy some modular rules. Since everything repeats every q steps, the lattice has a structured and periodic shape, convenient in cryptography.

Linear algebra modulo q , but breaking it requires solving a hard lattice problem.

Polynomial rings

NTRU paper (1996), first usage of polynomial quotient rings for lattice-based cryptography. Later ported over Ajtai/SIS-style and LWE, leading to Ring-SIS, Ring-LWE, and later on Module-LWE, etc.

$$(a_0, \dots, a_{n-1}) \in \mathbb{Z}_q^n \iff a(X) = a_0 + \dots + a_{n-1}X^{n-1} \in \mathbb{Z}_q[X]/(X^n + 1)$$

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- Addition: $a(x) + b(x) = \sum_{i=1}^d (a_i + b_i)X^i$
- Multiplication:

$$a(X) \cdot b(X) = \left(\sum_{i=0}^{n-1} \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} a_i b_j X^{i+j} \right) \in \mathbb{Z}_q[X]/(X^n + 1)$$

Since $X^n = -1$ then $X^{n+k} = -X^k$
 $\implies \mathcal{O}(n^2)$ naively, $\mathcal{O}(n \log n)$ using NTT.

Incomplete Timeline

- 1978 Knapsack cryptosystems attacked using lattice methods
- 1996 NTRU encryption, Ajtai
- 2005 Learning With Errors (LWE)
- 2008 Practical secure lattice-signature schemes
- 2009 Fully Homomorphic Encryption (FHE)
- 2016 NewHope (Ring-LWE KEM)
- 2017 Kyber (Module-LWE based), Dilithium (Module-LWE Module-SIS based), Falcon (NTRU based)
- 2020s standardization: ML-KEM (Kyber) and ML-DSA (Dilithium)

Hard problems in lattices - SVP and CVP

- In elliptic curve cryptography, we rely on the hardness of the Discrete Logarithm problem:
given publicly known $g, p \in \mathbb{G}$, find privately known $x \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that $p = g^x$.
- In lattice based cryptography, we rely on problems related to finding short vectors in the lattice.

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Definition (SVP (Shortest Vector Problem))

find a shortest non-zero vector $x \in \mathcal{L}$, ie. that minimizes the Euclidean norm $\|x\|$, that is $\lambda_1(\mathcal{L}) = \|x\|$.

Intuition: find the shortest possible jump from the origin to another dot

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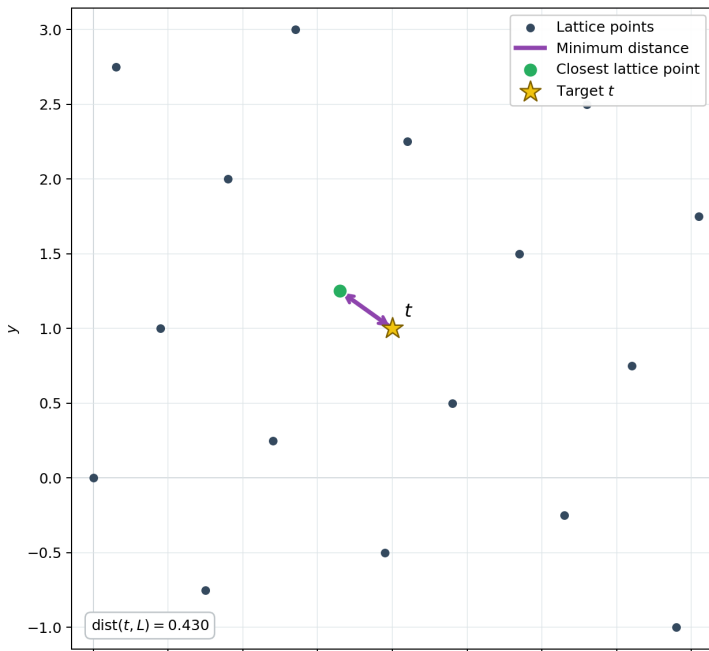
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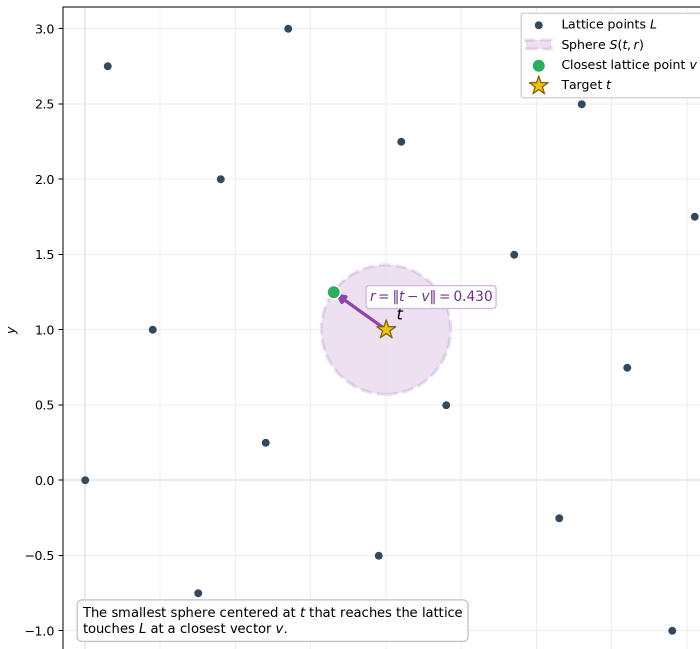
Definition (CVP (Closest Vector Problem))

given a vector $y \in \mathbb{R}^n$ with $y \notin \mathcal{L}$, find a nonzero vector $x \in \mathcal{L}$ that is closest to y , ie. that minimizes the Euclidean norm $\|y - x\|$.

Intuition: find the grid dot that is closest to a given point (off the grid)

Closest Vector Problem (CVP)



Closest Vector Problem: the target-centered sphere

Why Lattices?

- LLL algorithm is used to solve SVP and CVP.
 - LLL (Lenstra–Lenstra–Lovász): polynomial time method used for lattice basis reduction, which transforms a given basis of a lattice into a new basis that is shorter and nearly orthogonal, which makes SVP and CVP easier to approximate or solve using subsequent algorithms.

Intuition: make the lattice basis less skewed. Same grid of points, just a simpler basis. We don't change the lattice, we change the coordinate system used to describe it. → easier to solve SVP and CVP.

- improvement: BKZ reduction algorithm
- Both SVP and CVP become computationally difficult (NP hard) as the lattice dimension n grows (even on quantum computers)

Hard problems in lattices - SIS

Definition (SIS (Short Integer Solution))

given $q \in \mathbb{Z}$ and matrix $A \in \mathbb{Z}_q^{m \times n}$, find a non-zero short $z \in \mathbb{Z}^n$ s.th.

$$A \cdot z = 0 \pmod{q}$$

"short": $z \in \{\beta, \beta\}^n$ for some bound β , often $z \in \{-1, 0, 1\}^n$.

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The set of all solutions to the SIS problem forms the (q-ary) lattice

$$\Lambda_q^\perp(A) = \{z \in \mathbb{Z}^n \mid A \cdot z = 0 \pmod{q}\}$$

where the SIS problem becomes almost the SVP for $\Lambda_q^\perp(A)$

Intuition: find a short nonzero vector (not the shortest as in SVP) in the lattice $\Lambda_q^\perp(A)$

On the shortness of z

- without $\|z\| \leq \beta$, it is easy to find a solution via *Gaussian elimination*.
- $\beta < q$, because otherwise $z = (q, 0, \dots, 0) \in R^m$ would always be a valid solution.
- β and m must be large enough so that a solution is guaranteed to exist, usually $\beta \geq \sqrt{\hat{m}}$ and $m \geq \hat{m}$ where $\hat{m}$ is the smallest integer greater than $n \log q$.

TL;DR: z must be small enough for security reasons.

Again: overall when doing lattice-based cryptography, we will be interested into keeping the values *short*, aka. of small norm.

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(example of decomposing values to keep small norms when doing operations in cryptographic protocols (eg. in LaBRADOR))

Hard problems - LWE

Definition (LWE (Learning With Errors))

choose a matrix $A \in^R \mathbb{Z}_q^{m \times n}$, a secret vector $s \in^R \mathbb{Z}_q^n$, and an error vector $e \in^R [-B, B]^m$. Let $b = As + e \pmod{q} \in \mathbb{Z}_q^m$. Given the pair (A, b) , the goal is to recover s .

Search-LWE & Decisional-LWE problems.

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For LWE samples, vector b is relatively close to exactly one vector in the LWE lattice:

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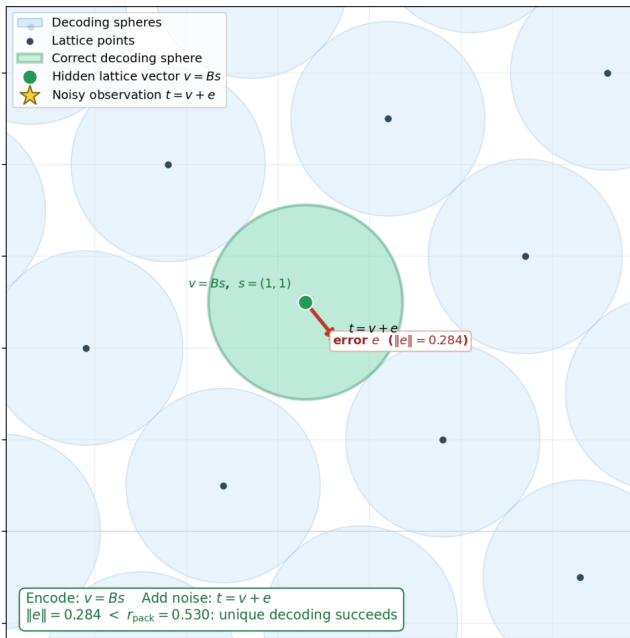
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Plain - Module - Ring

$$R_q = \mathbb{Z}_q[x]/(x^n + 1)$$

Assumption	Public linear relation	Underlying algebra
Plain LWE	$\mathbf{b} = A\mathbf{s} + \mathbf{e} \pmod{q}$	$A \in \mathbb{Z}_q^{m \times n}$
Module-LWE	$\mathbf{b} = A\mathbf{s} + \mathbf{e} \pmod{q}$	$A \in R_q^{k \times k}, \quad \mathbf{s}, \mathbf{e}, \mathbf{b} \in R_q^k$
Ring-LWE	$b = as + e \pmod{q}$	$a, s, e, b \in R_q$

Assumption	Public linear relation	Underlying algebra
Plain SIS	$A\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{0} \pmod{q}, \quad \mathbf{z} \neq \mathbf{0}, \quad \ \mathbf{z}\ \text{ small}$	$A \in \mathbb{Z}_q^{m \times n}, \quad \mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{Z}^n$
Module-SIS	$A\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{0} \pmod{q}, \quad \mathbf{z} \neq \mathbf{0}, \quad \ \mathbf{z}\ \text{ small}$	$A \in R_q^{m \times n}, \quad \mathbf{z} \in R^n$
Ring-SIS	$az = 0 \pmod{q}, \quad z \neq 0, \quad \ z\ \text{ small}$	$a \in R_q, \quad z \in R$

Lattice-based cryptography

Some examples

- ML-KEM (Kyber): Key Encapsulation Mechanism. ie. Alice encapsulates a (symmetric) key using Bob's public key
- ML-DSA (Dilithium): signature scheme
- FN-DSA (Falcon): signature scheme, based on NTRU
- LaBRADOR: SNARK scheme
- FHE (BFV, BGV, CKKS, TFHE)

Lattice-based cryptography

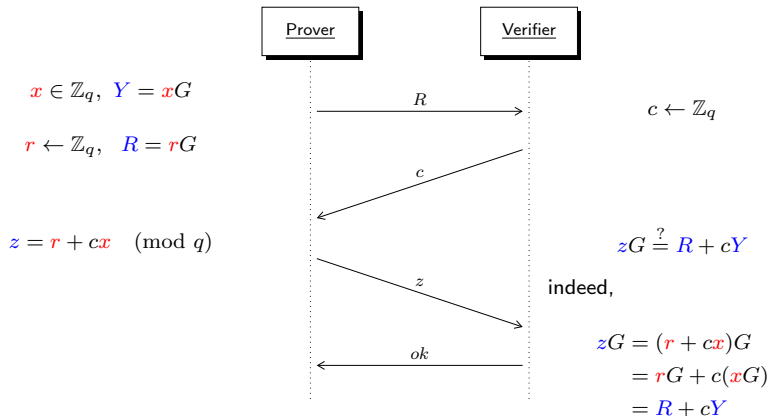
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Let's do a quick overview of ML-DSA (Dilithium)...

Recall: Sigma protocol over elliptic curve

$$G \in E(\mathbb{F}_p), \text{ ord}(G) = q, \text{ pub key } Y = xG$$



ML-DSA signatures

$$R_q = \mathbb{Z}_q[X]/(X^n + 1)$$

$$s_1 \leftarrow S^\ell, s_2 \leftarrow S^k$$

$$A \leftarrow R_q^{k \times \ell}, t = As_1 + s_2$$

$$y_1 \leftarrow Y^\ell, y_2 \leftarrow Y^k$$

$$w = Ay_1 + y_2$$

$$z_1 = y_1 + cs_1, z_2 = y_2 + cs_2$$

Reject if z_1, z_2 are not short.

Prover

Verifier

w

$$c \leftarrow C \text{ (in practice, } c = H(M||w)\text{)}$$

c

$$w \stackrel{?}{=} Az_1 + z_2 - ct$$

indeed,

$$\begin{aligned} &= A(y_1 + cs_1) + (y_2 + cs_2) \\ &\quad - c(As_1 + s_2) \end{aligned}$$

z_1, z_2

$$\begin{aligned} &= Ay_1 + cAs_1 + y_2 + cs_2 - cAs_1 - cs_2 \\ &= Ay_1 + y_2 = w \end{aligned}$$

ok

Accept if z_1, z_2 are short.

Benchmarks

Digital signatures

Scheme	Assumption	Public key size	Signature size
ECDSA-secp256k1	elliptic curves	33 B	64 B
Falcon-512	NTRU lattice	897 B	666 B
ML-DSA-44	Module-LWE / Module-SIS	1.31 KB	2.42 KB
XMSS-SHA2-10-256	hash based, stateful*	64 B	2.50 KB
SLH-DSA-128s (SPHINCS+)	hash based, stateless	32 B	7.86 KB

SNARKs / STARKs

Scheme	Assumption / technique	Proof size
Groth16	pairings / elliptic curves	128 B
LaBRADOR	Module-SIS	50–60 KB
Flock	binary fields + coding theory	200–400 KiB
Binius64	binary fields + sumcheck	200–500 KiB
Plonky2	Plonk + FRI	40–200 KB
Plonky3 / FRI-STARK	polynomial IOP + FRI	1–3 MiB

**stateful: signer needs to keep a state, keeping track of the leaves already used. Fine for validator nodes, potential trouble for wallets.*

- quantum threat forces us to prepare for it. Most companies are already preparing for migration to post-quantum
- no tool (scheme) for all use cases (eg. Ethereum validators vs wallets)
- lattice-based cryptography:
 - not a single assumption on all schemes: NTRU, R-SIS, M-SIS, R-LWE
 - actual operations (implementation) are over polynomial rings
 - often significantly smaller signatures/proofs than hash-based alternatives, at the cost of more algebraic complexity
 - often we're interested in 'short' values → typical trick: decompose bigger values before operate on them

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- what to read from here
 - *A Decade of Lattice Cryptography*, Chris Peikert
<https://eprint.iacr.org/2015/939>
 - *A gentle introduction to lattice-based cryptography*, Alfred Menezes
<https://eprint.iacr.org/2026/1098>